

Microcosm A small place or thing that has the traits of a larger counterpart (the macrocosm). In Hermeticism it refers to humankind, regarded as the representation in miniature of the universe.

Mystery cults Unofficial religions that came into existence during the ancient Roman period; built around secrecy and rituals, cult membership was selective.

Mysticism The belief that life has a hidden meaning or that each person can unite with a deity or absolute truth by deep contemplation of spiritual knowledge beyond the capacity of the human intellect; also used in a more general sense to mean belief in religion, spirituality, or the occult.

Natural magic A medieval definition of magic whose effects were thought to be achieved through the occult (hidden) powers of nature.

Necromancy The magic of the dead. The word comes from *nekros*, Greek for “dead body,” and *manteia* for “divination,” and it was originally a way of acquiring knowledge from the dead. In the late medieval era, it came to mean the ritual conjuring of demons to gain insight into the future or achieve some other task that required their help.

Neopaganism A collective term for a number of modern attempts to revive what practitioners believe to be ancient pagan religious practices.

Neoplatonism A Greco-Roman school of philosophical thinking, based on some of the principles of ancient Greek Platonism. Its followers believe that all existence stems from a single source, which they consider divine, and that the human soul seeks union with this source.

Neoshamanism “New” forms of shamanism, or methods of seeking visions or healing. Neoshamanism comprises an eclectic range of beliefs and practices that involve attempts to attain altered states through trance-inducing rituals, and to communicate with a spirit world. *See also* Shaman.

Netherworld The world of the dead, another word for the underworld.

New Age A range of spiritual beliefs and practices that present an alternative to capitalism and look forward to a more harmonious future lived closer to nature. The movement began in Western countries in the 1970s and now has a broad range of adherents across the globe.

Nigromancy An alternative word for necromancy, used mostly in the medieval period in Europe.

Numerology Magic using numbers, believed to be strongly connected to the universe, to understand past events and predict the future.

Occult Secret mystical, supernatural, or magical powers, practices, or phenomena.

Omen An event regarded as a portent of good or evil.

Oneiromancy Interpretation of dreams.

Oracle Soothsayer believed to answer questions by delivering advice from a god, often in a cryptic form.

Ornithomancy Ancient Greek form of divination carried out by observing the flight of birds.

Palmistry An ancient form of divination that supposedly interprets a person’s character or life by studying the lines and mounds on the palm of their hand. Also called chiromancy or palm reading.

Pantheism The belief in many or all gods, or the belief that God exists in, and is the same as, all things, animals, and people within the universe.

Pentagram A five-pointed star used as a talisman in magical evocation. The word pentagram may be used interchangeably with pentacle. A pentacle also refers to a five-pointed star within a circle.

Performance magic Illusionistic tricks or seemingly impossible feats of, for example, endurance carried out to entertain.

Philter A magical potion that, when drunk, causes a person to fall in love with the giver.

Polytheism Belief in many different gods.

Poppet Also known as a poppit, moppet, mommet, or pippy, in folk magic and witchcraft, a doll made to represent a person, for casting spells on that person or to aid that person through magic.

Quack A fraudulent or ignorant pretender to medical skill—someone who claims, professionally or publicly, to have skill, knowledge, or qualifications they do not possess; a charlatan.

Ritual A set of fixed actions and sometimes words performed regularly, especially as part of a ceremony.

Rosicrucianism A 17th-century secret brotherhood that claimed to have discovered ancient esoteric wisdom and religious principles.

Rune Any of the letters of an ancient alphabet cut into stone or wood in the past by the people of Northern Europe, or any similar mark with a secret or magical meaning.

Sabbat Any of eight seasonal festivals, including the equinoxes and solstices, observed by many Neopagans. Sabbat may also refer to a witches’ Sabbath—a supposed meeting of witches.

Scry To see what will happen in the future, especially by looking into a reflective object such as a mirror or glass ball.

Seal of Solomon A symbol said to have been given to the biblical King Solomon by God in the form of a seal, and to have allowed him to control and banish demons.

Séance A demonstration during which a medium channels spirits, acting as an intermediary between those spirits and the people present.

Seer A person who claims to be able to predict what will happen in the future.